REFERENCE LETTER

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Nanterre, April 20th, 2021

I am writing this letter of recommendation at the request of Mr. Xiaoou Wang to support his application to the PhD program you are offering.

I had the pleasure of following Mr. Wang's work in the course "Computational Linguistics and Statistics with R", which I taught in 2020-2021. After a brief review of R basics (programming language, programming interface, objects, graphics), the course discusses statistical methods applied to linguistic questions on authentic corpora of varying sizes. Although it is part of a M2 NLP course, it is above all a linguistics course in the sense that the aim is to interpret the results in the light of how language works.

The course was given in French and the materials were in English. It broke down into of five sessions: 1. R fundamentals; 1bis. Descriptive statistics; 3. Hypothesis testing; 4. Multivariate statistics; 5. Linear models.

As a professor, I had the opportunity to observe Mr. Wang's participation, to appreciate his involvement in the general discussion that structures each course, and to evaluate his knowledge in the subjects covered. I must say that his performance in each of these areas was of a very high standard. Not only was Mr. Wang able to meet the demanding challenge of learning issues associated with a new discipline (linguistics) as well as a new programming language in a very short period of time, but he was also capable of augmenting his written work with personal contributions, a sign that he knows how to work on his own and he has a solid experience. Mr. Wang obtained the highest grade in his cohort: 19.5/20.

In summary, I strongly support Mr. Wang's application. With his motivation, his intellectual qualities, and his working skills, he is at the level of the best PhD students in his field. To recruit him would allow him to pursue the career he has chosen. It would also allow his new institution to benefit from his many qualities. Please let me know if you need further information from me.

Guillaume Desagulier